Deutsche Bank
Research

Q2 Corporate Bank Quarterly

A guide to Macro, Markets, Geopolitics & Tech for CFOs and Corporates

April 2026

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IMPORTANT RESEARCH DISCLOSURES LOCATED IN APPENDIX 1.

Introduction: Macro, Markets, Geopolitics & Tech

A guide for CFOs & Corporates

We're pleased to share our April 2026 Guide for CFOs and Corporates, providing essential insights into macroeconomics, markets, geopolitics and technology. This report offers critical analysis and perspectives to help corporate clients navigate today's complex economic environment.

Key highlights:

- Macroeconomic outlook: The Iran War is driving an energy price shock that threatens a global inflation shock, despite growth remaining resilient outside the euro area.
- Market analysis: Higher energy costs and rates are pulling on corporate earnings growth. Brent crude averages $84.80/bbl in our baseline. Dollar weakness narrative resumes.
- Geopolitics: A long-term solution between the US and Iran is likely, but post-conflict normalization will take months. Key Q2 events to watch: Xi-Trump summit (14-15 May) and Ukraine ceasefire talks.
- Artificial Intelligence: AI disruption concerns have waned somewhat, however, the software sector remains under intense scrutiny and Q1 outlook announcements will be critical.
- The future of monetary policy: The energy shock has materially shifted central bank trajectories. Fed on hold through 2026; ECB hiking twice. The US continues to lead stablecoin adoption.

Upcoming key macro events

04 April

27-28	JN	Bank of Japan decision
28-29	US	Federal Reserve meeting
29-30	EZ	ECB decision
30	UK	Bank of England decision

05 May

06 June

10-11	EZ	ECB decision
14-16	G7	G7 summit in France
15-16	JN	Bank of Japan decision
16-17*	US	Federal Reserve meeting
18	UK	Bank of England decision
18-19	EU	European Council meeting

07 July

01	IR	Ireland holds EU Council presidency
22-23	EZ	ECB decision
28-29	US	Federal Reserve meeting
30	UK	Bank of England decision
30-31	JN	Bank of Japan decision

08 August

09 September

-	FR	France Senate election
09-10	EZ	ECB decision
15-16*	US	Federal Reserve meeting
17	UK	Bank of England decision
17-18	JN	Bank of Japan decision
30	US	Fiscal-year ends- multiple agencies' funding expires

10 October

04-25	BR	Brazilian general election
27-28	US	Federal reserve meeting
28-29	EZ	ECB decision
29-30	JN	Bank of Japan decision

11 November

03	US	US midterm elections (House & Senate)
05	UK	Bank of England decision
09-20	COP31	COP31 in Türkiye

12 December

-	CH	China Central Economic Work Conference
08-09*	US	Federal reserve meeting
14-15	G20	G20 summit in US
16-17	EZ	ECB decision
17	UK	Bank of England decision
17-18	JN	Bank of Japan decision

Source: The House View: Infographic - 2026 Global Macro Events Calendar – 06-Jan-2026

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DB forecasts

GDP Growth (%)	2024	2025	2026F	2027F
Global	3.4	3.4	3.3	3.3
US	2.8	2.1	2.4	2.2
Eurozone	0.9	1.5	0.5	1.1
Germany	-0.5	0.2	0.5	1.3
France	1.1	0.9	1.0	1.1
Italy	0.6	0.7	0.8	1.0
Spain	3.5	2.8	2.2	2.1
Japan	-0.2	1.2	0.8	1.0
UK	1.1	1.4	0.9	1.2
China	5.0	5.0	4.9	4.5
India	7.2	7.5	6.7	7.2
Russia	4.9	1.0	0.8	1.3
Asia (ex Japan)	5.4	5.5	5.2	5.1
EEMEA	3.4	3.0	2.9	3.3
LatAm	2.5	1.9	2.0	1.8
EM	4.6	4.5	4.3	4.4

- *CPI (%) forecasts are period averages. **Germany National CPI taken.
  EEMEA: Czech Rep., Israel, Egypt, Hungary, Poland, Russia, Saudi Arabia, South Africa, Turkey, UAE
- LATAM (ex Venezuela): Argentina, Brazil, Chile, Colombia, Mexico, Peru
- ASIA (ex Japan): China, HK, India, Indonesia, Korea, Malaysia, Philippines, Singapore, Sri Lanka, Taiwan, Thailand, Vietnam
- Current prices as of April 28, 2026.
- *China rates are 7d OMO rates.
- **Gold, Brent and WTI forecasts are for Q2 / Q3 / Q4 2026.

CPI Inflation, YoY* (%)	2025	2026F	2027F	2028F
US	2.7	3.3	2.5	2.5
Eurozone	2.1	2.8	2.2	2.2
Germany**	2.2	2.9	2.4	2.9
Japan	3.2	1.8	2.2	2.2
UK	3.4	3.1	2.6	2.0
China	0.1	1.5	2.0	2.0
India	2.2	4.6	4.2	
Russia	8.7	5.7	5.4	

Central Bank policy rate (%)	Current	Jun 26F	Sep 26F	Dec 26F
US	3.625	3.625	3.625	3.625
Eurozone	2.00	2.25	2.50	2.50
UK	3.75	3.75	3.75	3.75
Japan	0.75	0.75	1.00	1.00
China*	1.40	1.40	1.40	1.40
India	5.25	5.25	5.25	5.25

Key market metrics	Current	Jun 26F	Sep 26F	Dec 26F
US 10Y Yield (%)	4.34	4.30	4.45	4.45
EUR 10Y Yield (%)	3.03	2.90	3.00	3.10
EUR/USD	1.17	1.20	1.22	1.25
USD/JPY	159	155	152	150
USD/CNY	6.83	6.80	6.80	6.70
S&P 500	7174	7450	7675	8000
**Oil WTI (USD/bbl)	97.51	90	82	73
**Oil Brent (USD/bbl)	109.56	96	87	78
**Gold	4669	5,100	5,500	5,800

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Source: Deutsche Bank Research, Bloomberg Finance LP.

01.
Macroeconomics

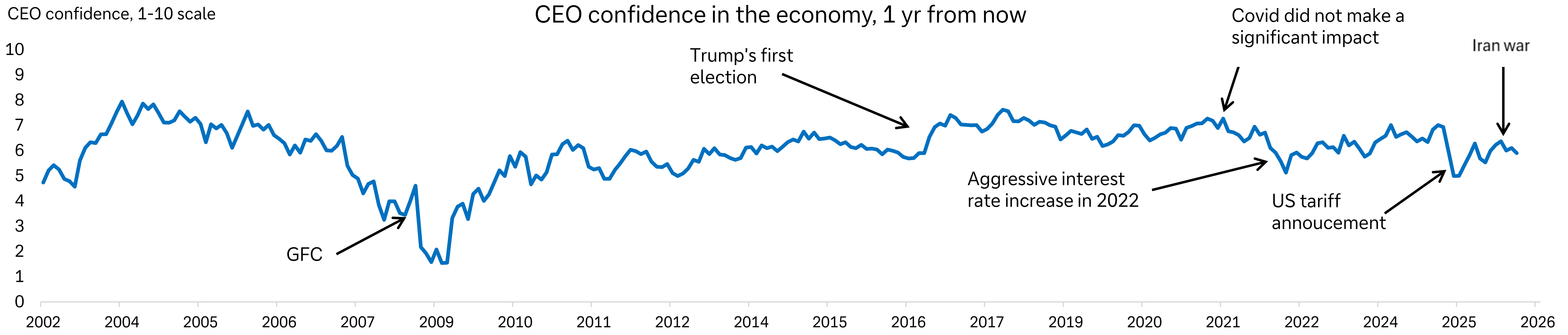
2026 Global growth

Energy shock weighs on growth, especially in the Euro Area

	View	Rationale
	Growth at 3.3% in 2026 and 2027.	– The energy price shock from the Iran war is reverberating through the global economy, although the impact varies across regions.
	Growth revised to 2.4% in 2026 (2.3% q4/q4) and 2.2% in 2027 (2.2% q4/q4).	– The downgrade reflects the drag from higher oil prices and softer consumer spending, counterbalanced by continued tailwinds from supportive fiscal policy, and strong AI investments.
	Euro area growth decreased to 0.5% in 2026 and 1.1% in 2027. German GDP downgraded to 0.5% in 2026 and 1.3% in 2027.	– The energy shock is impacting the region at a time when growth was already softening, lowering the bar to stagnation or even recession.

	View	Rationale
	Growth increased to 4.9% in 2026, 4.5% in 2027.	– Strong performance driven by a +15% y/y export surge in Q1, rebound in domestic investment, and some stabilization in the property sector.
EM	Notable downward growth revisions due to Iran war, including India (FY27 growth 6.7% from 7.5%).	– In Asia, fuel price controls have limited immediate inflation rise, but full effects will emerge as domestic prices adjust over time to higher imported input prices. – CEEMEA has largest upward inflation revisions, but more limited drag on activity and sentiment compared to Asia. LatAM impact less pronounced, electoral cycles remain in focus.

The drop in corporate sentiment from the Iran war is not as steep as one may think



Read: Global Economics: Monthly Flyover (April 2026) - Deutsche Bank Research

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3 key risks for the global economy

The growing economic effects of the war in the Middle East are raising further questions about the government response, not just in the US but also in Europe.

1. Iran conflict

- Oil-driven energy crisis risks global stagflation, leading to higher prices and slower growth for corporates.
- Despite volatile environment, the probability of a long-term solution is strong.

2. Private credit

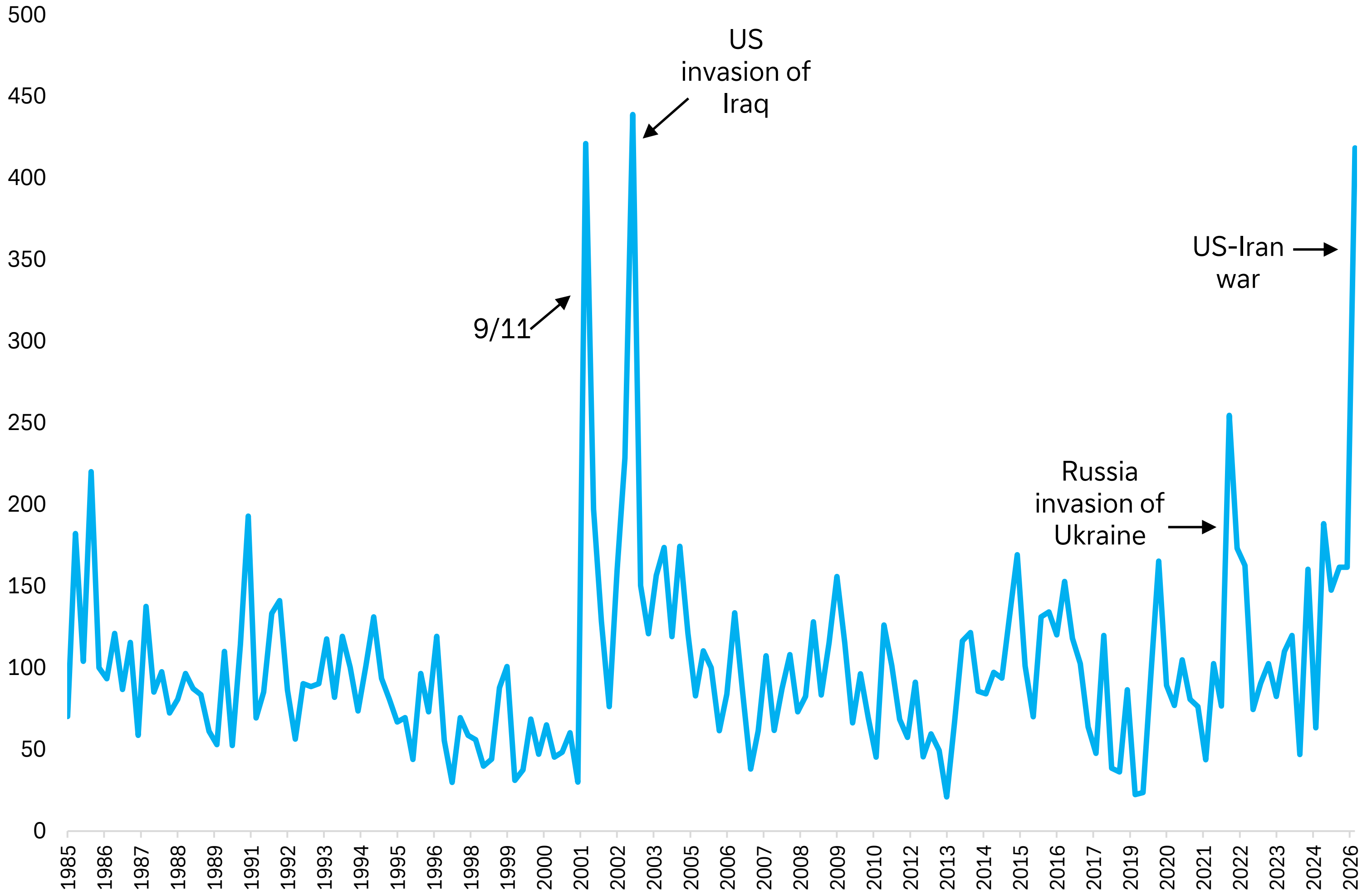
- Liquidity pressures are building but default rates remain low while the most material exposures are with larger managers with more buffer.
- There are expectations of a severe shock (BDCs' discount to NAV is about 20%) however, this fear has been relatively muted in broader public credit markets.

3. AI disruption

- Concerns that AI will disrupt the labour force are, so far, unfounded in aggregate. The most likely scenario remains that job losses will be limited to specific roles and most will use AI to amplify existing roles.
- The Nasdaq has recovered from another AI-related sell-off.

Geopolitical uncertainty is now at its highest level since the US invasion of Iraq

Caldara Iacoviello Geopolitical Risk Index, quarterly uncertainty



Source: Deutsche Bank Research, Caldara, Iacoviello Geopolitical Risk Index. Takes automated text-search results of the electronic archives of newspapers

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Central banks

The energy shock has shifted central bank trajectories

Fed
- Fed to remain on hold near neutral through 2026.
- Core PCE (2.9% q4/q4) set to remain above target, coupled with labour market stabilization, makes chances of easing unlikely.

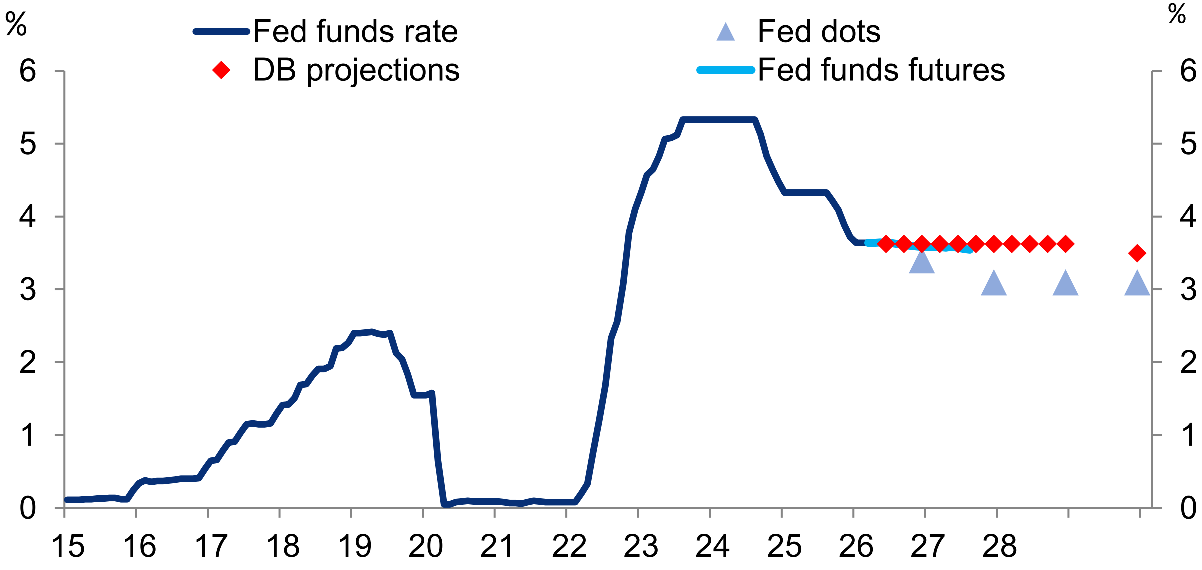
ECB
- 25bp hikes in Jun and Sep to 2.50% year-end, previously on hold.
- 2.5% at the upper end of neutral; ECB is sending signal on their commitment to price stability.

BoE
- On hold at 3.75% through 2026. Upside risks stem from energy prices trickling down into core goods and food.

BoJ
- 25bps hikes in Jul and Jan 27, 1.25% by Jan 2027.

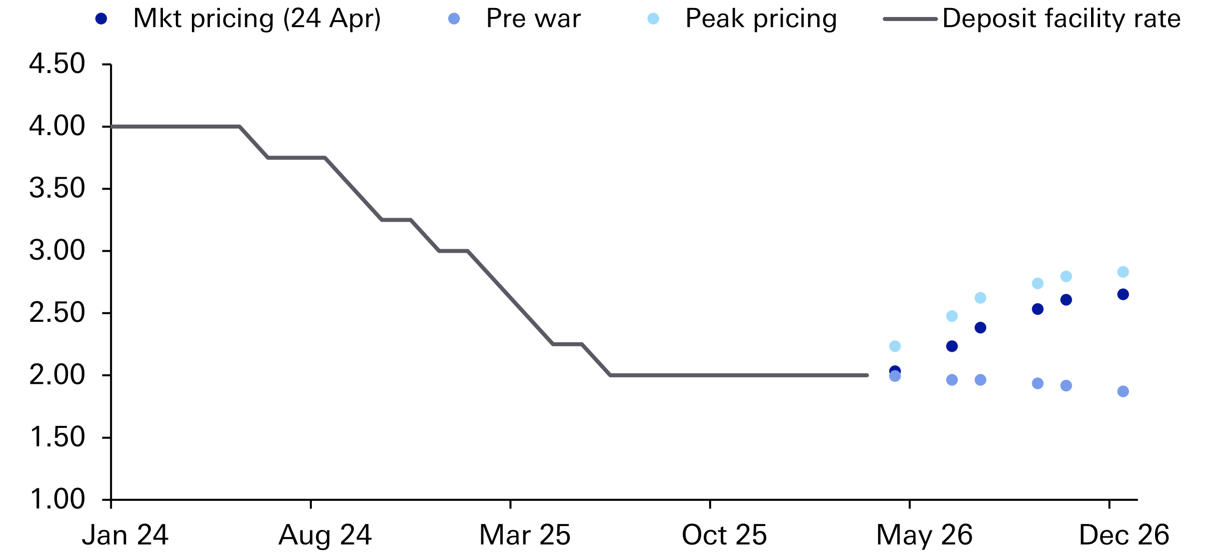
PBoC
- Hold at 1.40% through 2026.

FED: Central bank is done cutting interest rates from here



Source: FRB, Bloomberg Finance LP, Haver Analytics, Deutsche Bank Research. Updated April 24, 2026

ECB: 2.50% YE, previously 2.0%



Source: Deutsche Bank Research, ECB. Updated April 24, 2026

Read: Focus Europe: ECB Preview: Tough talk, tough decisions - Deutsche Bank Research and Fed Notes: FOMC preview: Powell's last dance? - Deutsche Bank Research

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02.

Geopolitics

Iran conflict

An end in sight?

While diplomacy is continuing, the situation remains extremely fragile. The two sides' postures continue to diverge on Iran's nuclear programme, the pace of sanctions relief, potential reparations, Iranian support for its proxies, and long-term control of the Strait of Hormuz. While the ceasefire has been extended, the crisis remains unresolved and we should expect continued escalations and bellicose rhetoric by all parties to the conflict.

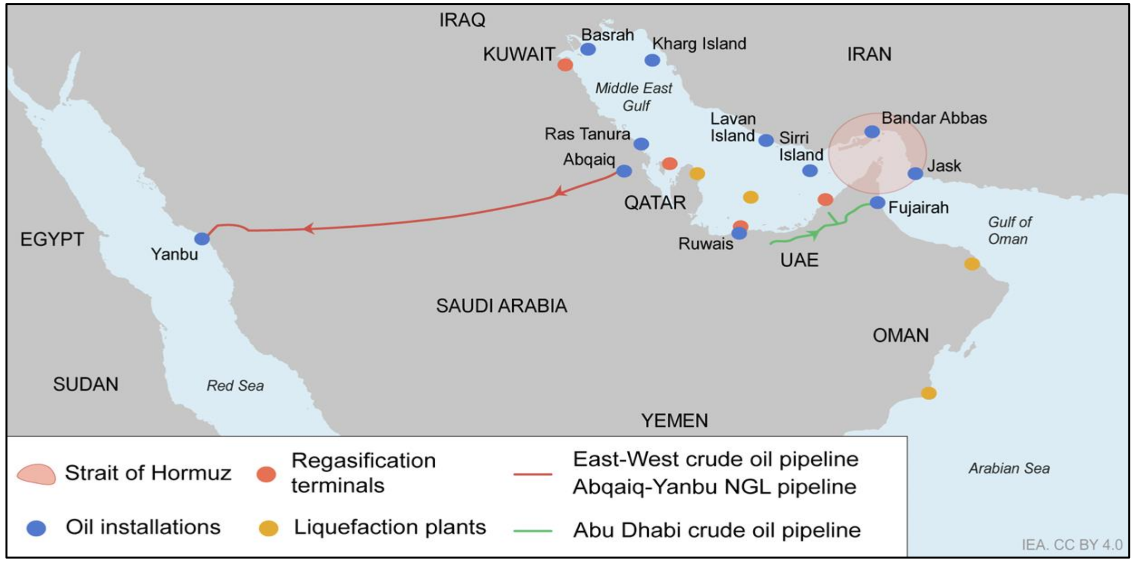
Despite the precarious nature of the ceasefire, and the added uncertainty due to the US blockade of the Strait of Hormuz, we assess that the probability of a longer-term solution is strong. The US is facing diminishing returns and growing costs. We have already witnessed increasing domestic and international pressure on Trump, which we expect will only increase as the economic fallout of crisis persists and expands.

However this ends, it will be a gamechanger for the Middle East. The long-standing Middle East geopolitical equilibrium has been shattered. Iran will likely walk away from this conflict with enhanced influence over the Strait of Hormuz, potential sanctions relief, and with greater political leverage having withstood the US and Israeli attacks. Meanwhile, the conflict illustrates that the Gulf is no longer buffered from conflict. Consequently, its relationship with the US will inevitably be impacted. We expect to see a diversification in Gulf relations in the aftermath of the acute crisis.

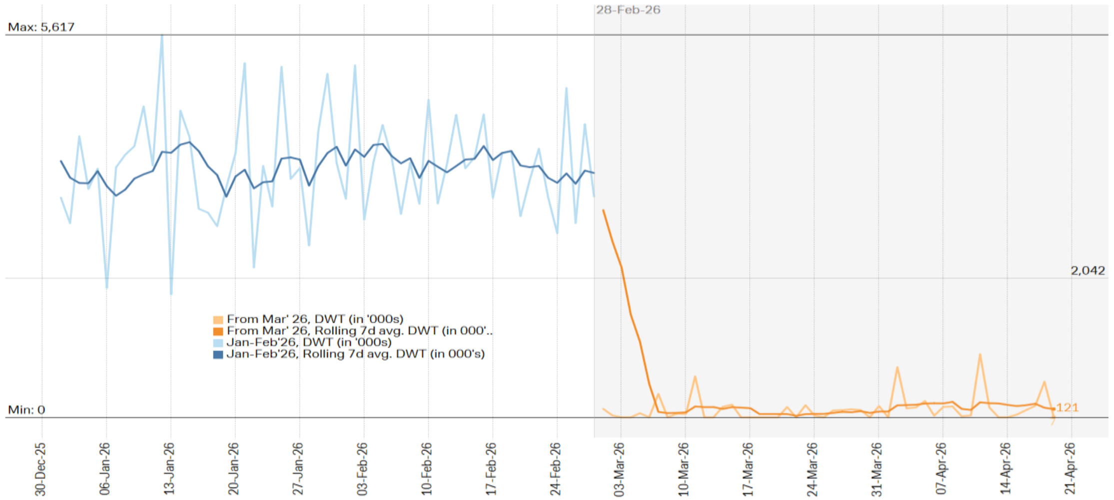
Post-conflict normalization could take months. Even if the war concludes in the near term, rebuilding critical infrastructure and restoring shipping and energy flows will take significant time. For example, repairs to Qatar's Ras Laffan natural gas field – the world's largest – could take months, inevitably delaying a rebound in global supply.

A rebound in shipping (see chart) will also be contingent on confidence – both by shippers and insurers – that the Strait of Hormuz is safe and clear of mines. This could take weeks beyond an end to the conflict. Significant knock-on effects, including for inflation, could continue well into 2026-H2 even with a near-term peace deal, including in the form of jet fuel and fertilizer shortages.

Oil and gas infrastructure in the Gulf



Tanker activity exiting the Strait of Hormuz (in DWT'000s)



Source: Deutsche Bank Research, International Energy Agency, dbDataInsights.

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Other geopolitical flashpoints

Key topics to monitor during 2026-Q2

- Trump-Xi Summit: Barring a significant escalation in the Iran war, the summit between presidents Xi and Trump on 14-15 May will likely go ahead as planned – and deliver a package of tactical economic agreements. Despite recent signs of friction over Iran, both sides appear to be prioritizing bilateral stability for 2026, and the threshold for another summit deferral is likely high. However, a breakdown of the US-Iran ceasefire and a return to fighting would be a notable downside risk, which would increase the probability of another summit delay, or even a cancellation.

- Putin's visit to China: It will likely aim to cement the China-Russia partnership (including more energy supplies for Beijing), and possibly to coordinate US policies after the Xi-Trump summit. Unconfirmed Russian media reports suggest Putin could visit during the week of 18 May. Putin and Xi could also seek to deepen diplomatic and security ties, and coordinate on the Iran conflict, given Tehran's status as both countries' close partner.

- Ukraine ceasefire talks: Negotiations for a ceasefire in Ukraine are largely stalled. While there is ongoing diplomatic activity, no new rounds of ceasefire talks are publicly scheduled for May or June. Ukrainian President Zelenskyy has stated that the US wants Russia and Ukraine to reach a peace agreement by June. However, the specifics of how this would manifest in terms of scheduled meetings are unclear.

- While a ceasefire over the coming months is far from guaranteed, even credible steps toward a deal would have implications for markets. These could include a possible easing of some sanctions on Russia, the potential for increased Ukrainian agriculture exports, and for enabling reconstruction – with implications for investments in minerals, gas infrastructure, technology, city reconstruction, data centres and artificial intelligence.

For more on geopolitical flashpoints to watch out for, read our recent publications here:
Iran Ceasefire: An End in Sight? ; This Month in Geopolitics: April 2026 ; Geopolitical Crossroads: India's Strategic Balancing Act ; High-Stakes Diplomacy: Navigating the Xi-Trump Summit in the Shadow of Iran

Source: Weichao Deng on Unsplash

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Selected geopolitical events in April - June

- **7 May:** UK local elections and Scottish and Welsh parliamentary elections.
- **8-9 May:** The Philippines will host the ASEAN Leaders' Summit.
- **11-12 May:** EU foreign and defence ministers meetings.
- **14-15 May:** Presidents Xi and Trump are expected to meet in Beijing.
- **Mid-May:** President Putin is expected to visit Beijing.
- **Mid-May:** Indian Prime Minister Narendra Modi is expected to visit the Netherlands, Norway and Italy.
- **22 May:** Nuclear Non-Proliferation Review Conference concludes in New York.
- **29-31 May:** Singapore will host the annual Shangri-La Dialogue defence summit.
- **31 May:** Colombia Presidential election first round
- **Late May:** US Secretary of State Marco Rubio will visit India for talks.
- **Late May/Early June:** The OECD Ministerial Council Meeting is expected to take place in Paris.
- **11 June:** FIFA World Cup begins in US, Canada and Mexico
- **15-17 June:** France will host the G7 Leaders' Summit in Évian.
- **19 June:** European Council meeting
- **1 July:** The first review of the US-Mexico-Canada (USMCA) trade agreement begins.

Source: aboodi vesakaran on Unsplash

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03.

Markets

Commodity markets

The key question: When do the stresses in financial assets directly affected by the war begin to catalyse confidence problems in broader markets?

Oil: Brent $96/bbl (Q2'26), $84.8/bbl (2026) average, assuming the Strait of Hormuz will re-open in May.

- Improving but uncertain backdrop, thanks to (i) supply diversion and remaining flows limiting the magnitude of oil supply disruption; and (ii) significant demand reduction rising to -2.3mmb/d y/y in April, according to the IEA.
- Risks: Longer suspension of the SoH (reopening beyond May) could accelerate the run-up in Brent well above $100/bbl near term. This would translate into higher-for-longer inflation.
- Central banks' ability to look-through supply shocks is tested.

Gold: moderate YE target to $5,000/oz (prevs. $6,000/oz)

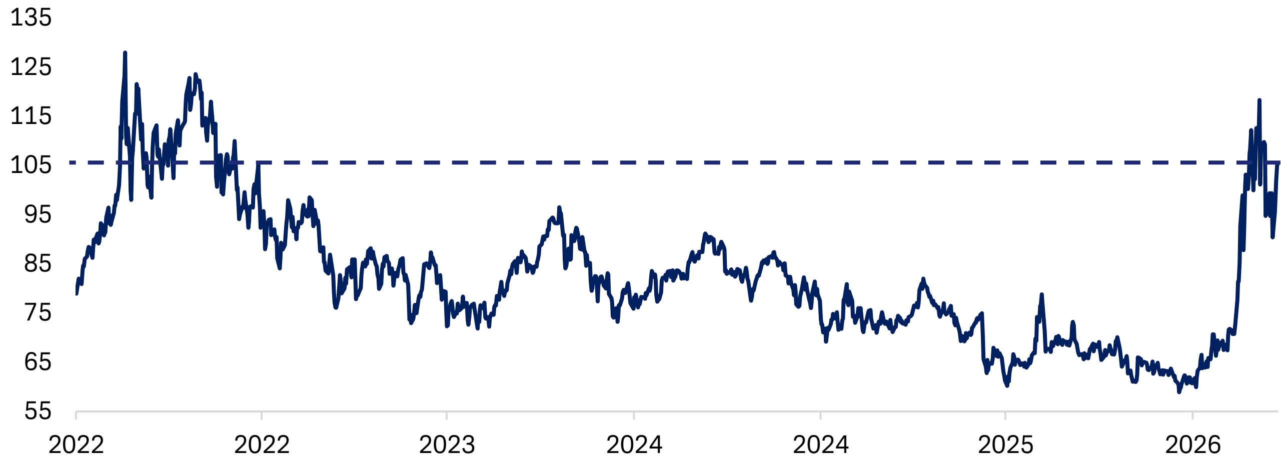
- Forecast based on belief that dollar weakness will resume.

Latest oil price forecasts

USD	2025	Q1 2026	Q2 2026	Q3 2026	Q4 2026	2026	2027
WTI (bbl)	64.9	72.7	90.0	82.0	73.0	79.4	71.0
% change		-0.5%	12.5%	9.3%	4.3%	6.6%	4.4%
Brent (bbl)	68.20	78.10	96.00	87.00	78.00	84.80	75.00
% change		0.1%	12.9%	8.7%	4.0%	6.6%	4.2%

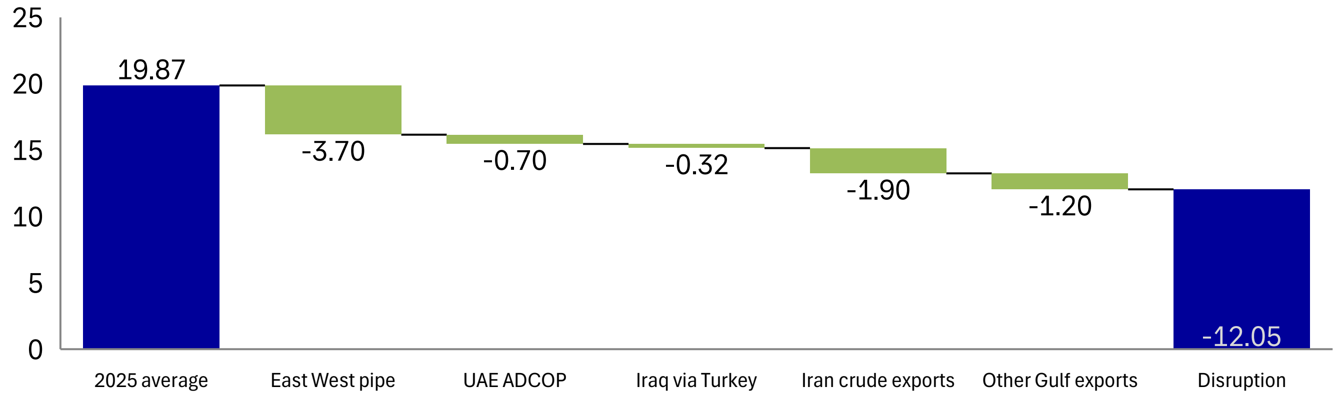
Reports: Hsueh On Oil: Problem solved? - Deutsche Bank Research and Precious Special Report: Gold investors to emerge from war bunker - Deutsche Bank Research

Brent crude oil prices ($/bbl) have risen but are clearly lower today than they were in 2022



Source: Deutsche Bank Research, Bloomberg Finance LP

Strait of Hormuz April supply disruption down to 12mmb/d



Source: Deutsche Bank Research, Bloomberg Finance LP, IEA, Kpler

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Rates & Credit markets

Dual shock of higher rates and energy costs introduces some uncertainty whether strong corporate growth forecasts will continue into year-end

Private credit outflows have had some effect on broader leveraged loans and some larger US money centres/regional banks, tightening financial conditions somewhat.

- Private credits remain centred on AI disruption, particularly in the software sector, rather than the ongoing energy shock.
- We see credit spreads to widen throughout 2026, with €HY 420bps, $HY at 410bps YE and €IG at 110bps, $IG at 110bps YE.
- In Europe, weaker macro fundamentals plus energy shock driven restrictive policy rates also account for wider spreads. Political risks in Europe are growing.

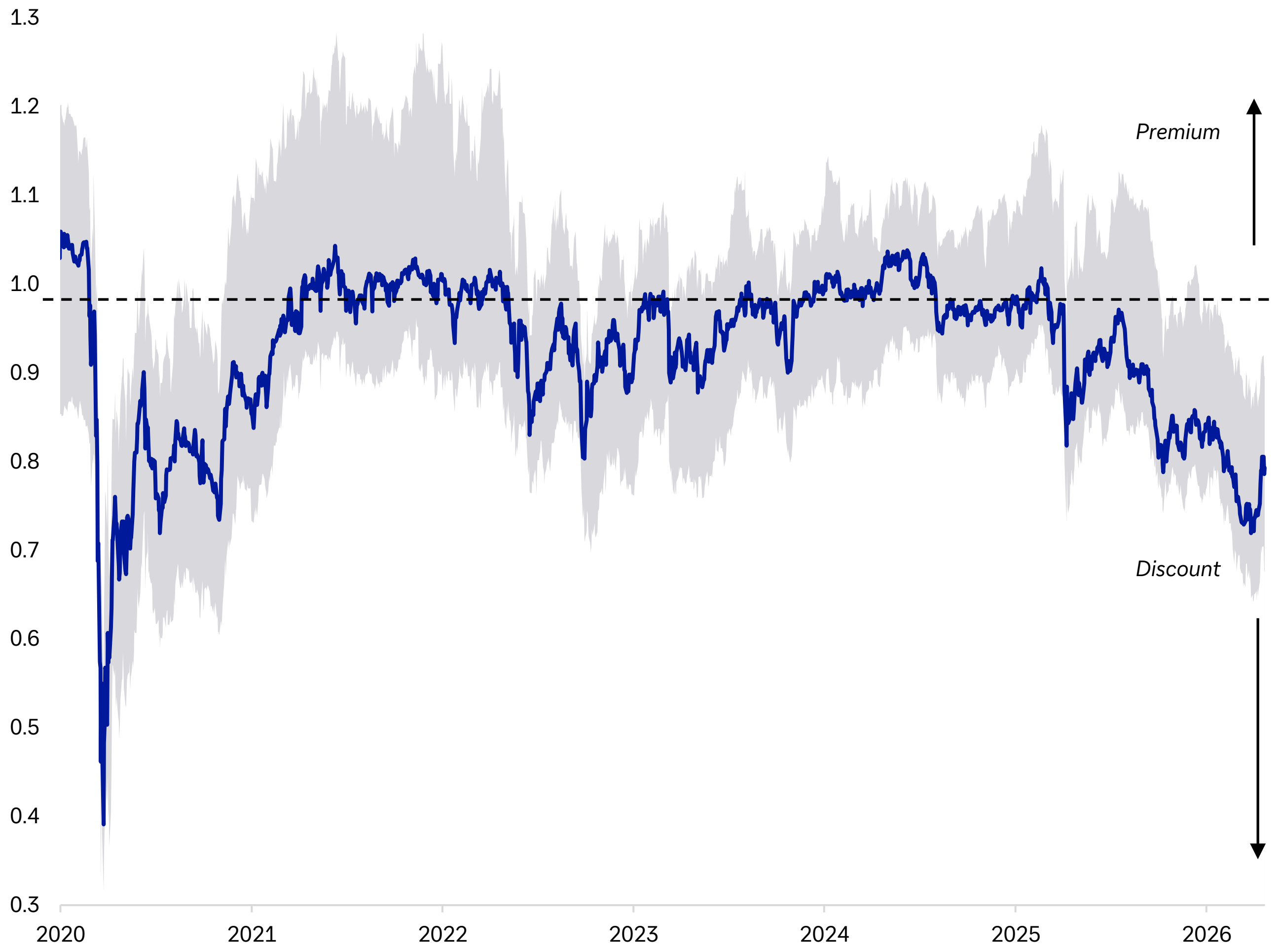
We retain our conviction that the 10Y US Treasury Yield will continue to fall, impacting corporate funding costs.

- Difficult to justify further Fed rate cuts given (i) unemployment rate is broadly stable; (ii) inflation is sticky above 2% and; (iii) policy rates are unlikely to be restrictive.
- AI tailwinds (either bubble or labour market impact) potentially challenge our bearish view on 10Y UST (4.45% by YE).

Reports: IG & HY Strategy: The Narratives Are Turning Upside Down - Deutsche Bank Research and IG & HY Strategy: Private Credit: The gates are up, but the problem is within - Deutsche Bank Research and Global Fixed Income Weekly: Strategy Update - Deutsche Bank Research

US business development companies are a key proxy for the market's private credit concerns. The current discount to NAV of about 20% suggests investors expect severe stress events.

Median price-to-NAV ratio of funds in the S&P BDC index



Source: Deutsche Bank Research, S&P Global. See: Thematic Research: Private capital monitor: Fear and loathing - Deutsche Bank Research

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Foreign exchange markets

The dollar bullish narrative has eroded, staying dollar bearish

Despite some reprieve during war, big picture remains dollar bearish

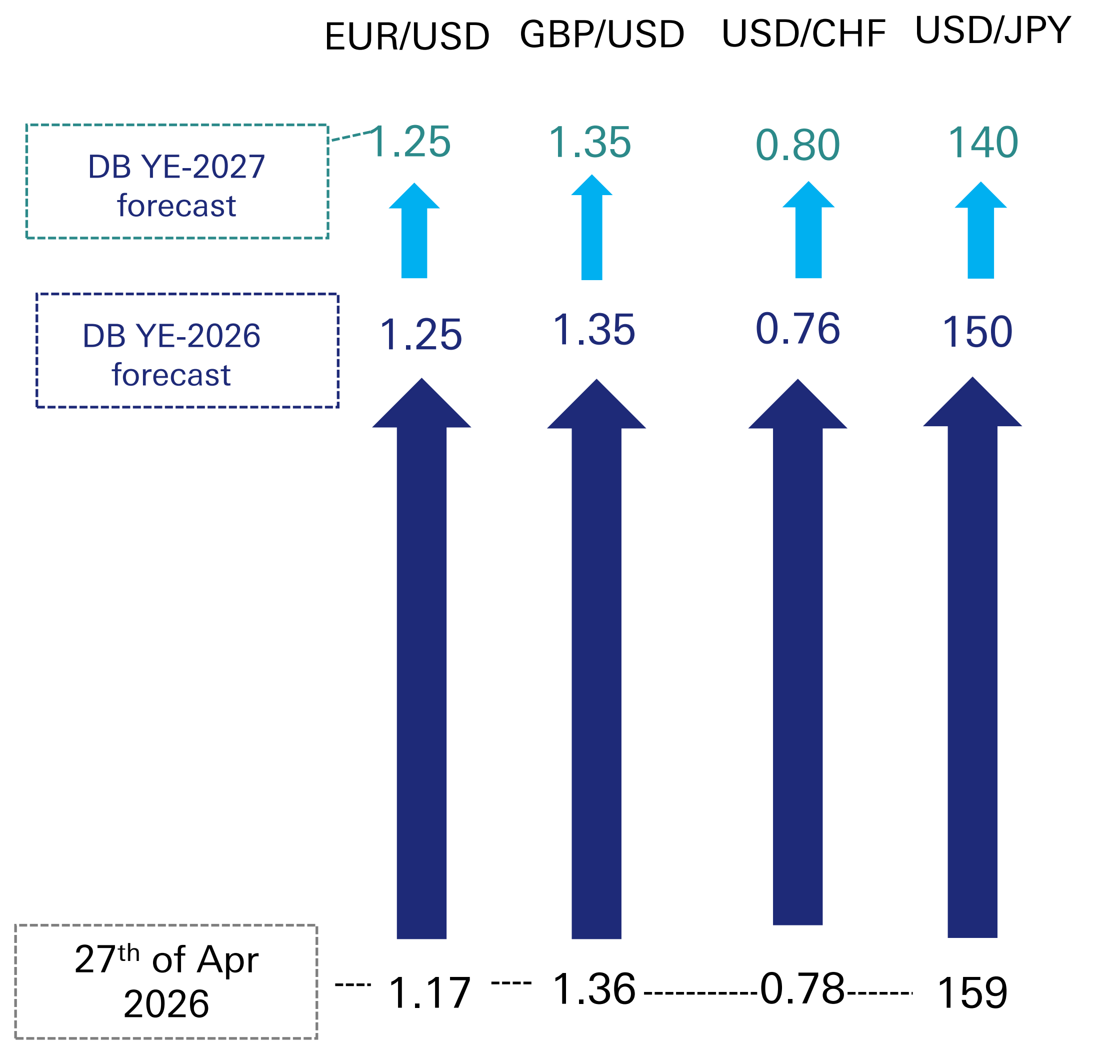
- Usually, we would expect the dollar (as a haven currency) to have rallied more than it did during the Iran war. That highlights some weakness.
- Strengthens the argument that the USD is still no longer as exceptional as a high-yielder and as a global growth outlier.
- The Iran war exacerbated dollar weakness due to Asia and the Middle East running down FX reserves and excess savings to finance higher energy costs. Countries were already moving away from the USD into smaller, unspecified reserve currencies (up from 3% to 6% of these assets in the last 3 years).

Currency outlook

- EUR/USD: Rise to $1.25 by year-end. While the energy price spike complicates the Euro Area's growth picture, it has also brought forward the ECB rate hike cycle, leading to a stronger Euro.
- USD/JPY: Raised end-2026 to 150. JPY remains very cheap as the BOJ remains unlikely to tighten policy rates this year.
- RMB: Supported by de-escalation in US-China tensions and the government's continued aims to internationalise the yuan. RMB remains cheap but a stronger RMB would increase the appeal for global corporates to transition to using and saving in the yuan, especially if most Middle East energy continues to travel to Asia. Corporates continue to have scope to increase conversion of their large stock and flow of FX into RMB.

Read: FX Blog: Time to sell USD - Deutsche Bank Research and The Big FX View: War and Peace - Deutsche Bank Research

Currency movements and DB forecasts for YE-2026 and 2027



Source: Deutsche Bank Research, Bloomberg Finance LP.

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04.
Technology

Artificial intelligence

AI disruption concerns are rising in 2026, but there is no conclusive relationship between modest job declines and substitution with AI

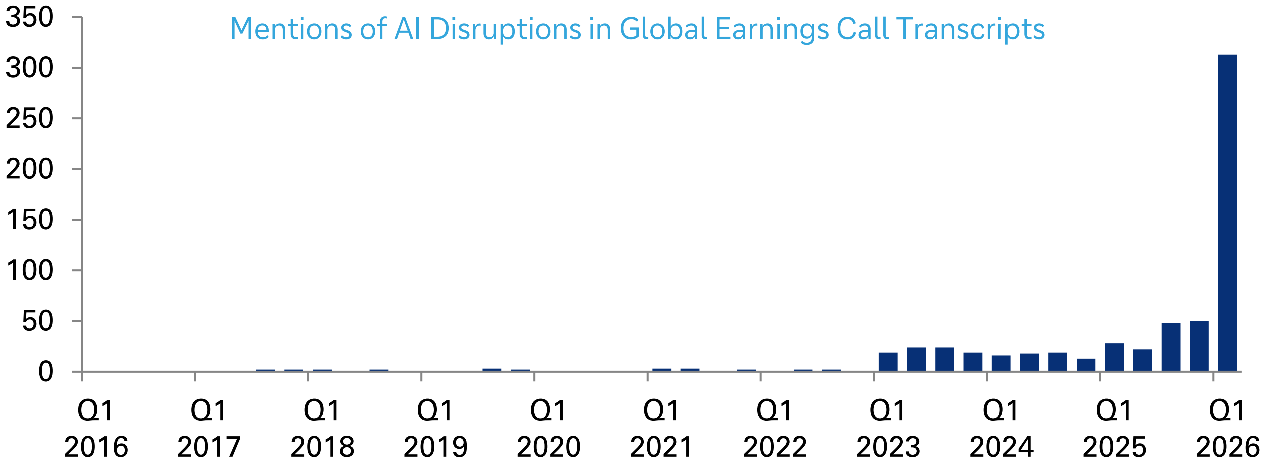
Job displacement from AI remains a concern, but the aggregate evidence so far is encouraging

- A Dec 2025 NBER study suggests that AI, by substituting primarily cognitive tasks, can shift relative demand away from high-skilled roles toward jobs with lower education, lower wages and more male workers.
- The evidence is still inconclusive, as noted by our US analysts. A survey by Indeed found no noticeable deterioration amongst roles of recent market concerns, such as legal, marketing, accounting and management.

The case for AI's positive benefits is growing

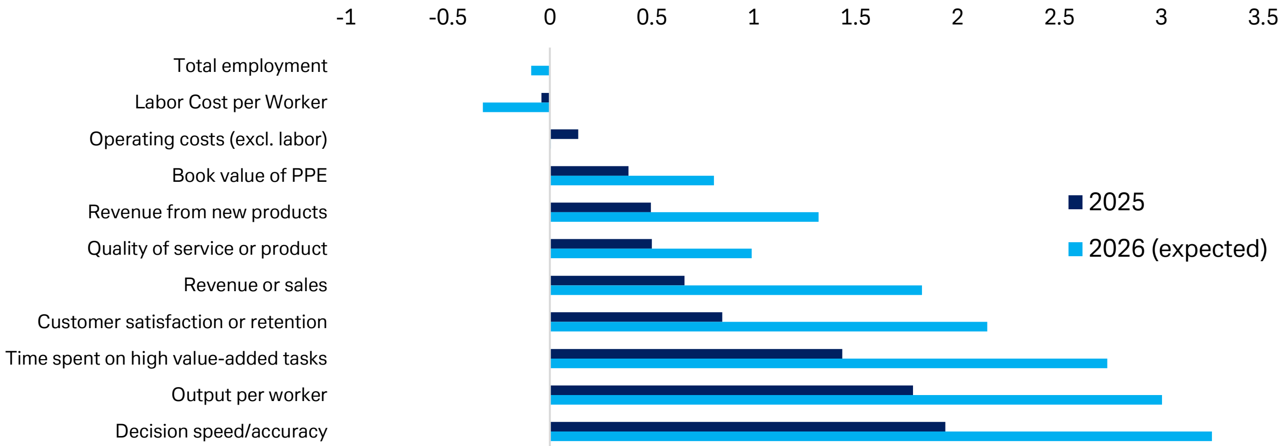
- According to an Atlanta Fed survey, business executives are already seeing labour productivity gains from AI and anticipate it to double in 2026. Firms in high-skill services are seeing the greatest gains. Finance, for example, saw productivity growth of 0.8% last year, implied by revenues and employment, a figure which is set to exceed 2% in 2026.
- Firms in manufacturing and construction saw smaller but still positive implied gains of roughly 0.4 percent in 2025.
- The study found that productivity gains were associated with innovation and demand-orientated channels rather than cost reduction alone.

In Q1 26, mentions increased more than sixfold from Q4 2025 in earnings calls.



Source: Deutsche Bank Research, Bloomberg Finance LP.

Impact of AI usage on firm outcomes



Source: Deutsche Bank Research, The CFO Survey, Federal Reserve Bank of Richmond, Federal Reserve Bank of Atlanta. Question asks for likert scale options that are mapped to percentage outcomes (i.e. increased moderately, 5.1 to 10%. Above chart uses midpoint of ranges provided and +/- 5% above/below highest/lowest options to calculate numeric averages across respondents.

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Artificial intelligence

Companies will continue to invest in AI to varying degrees, but lack of trust remains a key barrier

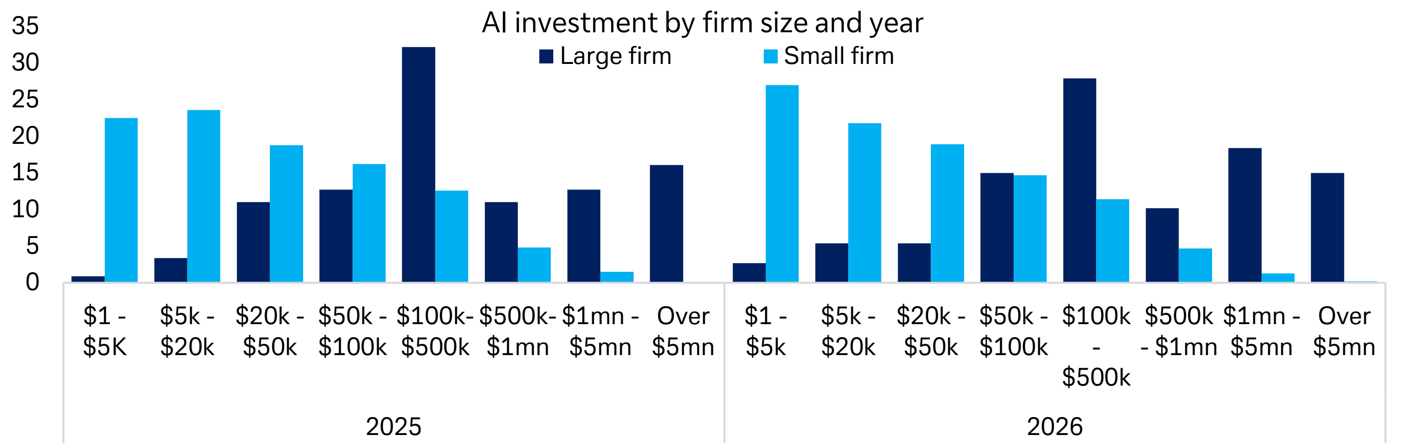
Company adoption continues to be underway, with more pickup in 2026

- Large firms led corporate AI adoption in 2025; smaller firms are only beginning to invest in AI now, according to a survey led by the Atlanta Fed and Richmond Fed.
- Around 30% of large firms expect to invest more than $1mn in AI in 2026 (vs 1% of small firms). But nearly 60% of smaller firms plan to invest less than $20,000 in AI in 2026 (vs 14% of larger firms).

Western economies lag in AI trust and adoption

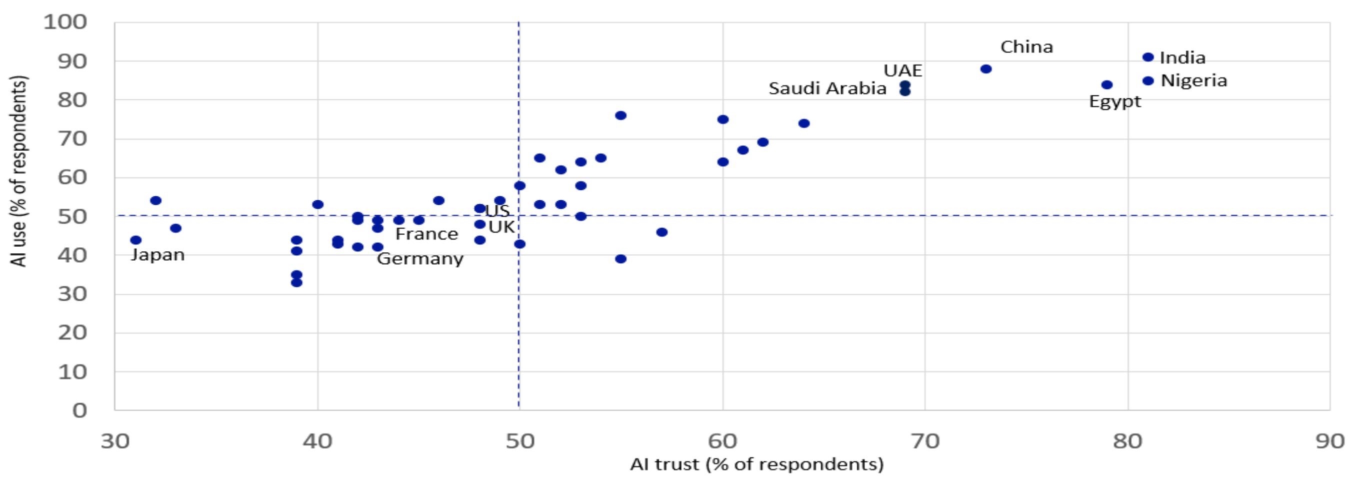
- Barriers to adoption continue to be lack of workforce training, belief AI is not yet sufficiently mature and privacy concerns (see here)
- While the US leads in the most advanced models and chips, and accounts for half of the world's data centres, US consumers are more suspicious of AI than their peers in markets such as India, the UAE, China and Saudi Arabia. Western consumers also lag behind in adoption.
- 48% of US consumers say they trust AI for work purposes, and only 52% say they use it on a regular basis, according to a survey.
- That compares with well over two-thirds trusting AI for work in the leading Asian and Gulf markets and around 85 to 90 percent using it.

80% of firms will invest in AI in 2026, with large firms to invest the most, according to a CFO survey led by the Atlanta Fed and Richmond Fed



Source: Deutsche Bank Research, The CFO Survey. Large firms have > 500 employees. What do you expect your company's total expenditure and financial investment in AI technology/solutions will be over the next 12 months? Federal Reserve Bank Richmond, Federal Reserve Bank Atlanta.

Western economies lag behind their peers in trust in AI and intentional use at work



Source: Deutsche Bank Research, University of Melbourne, KPMG.

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Digital currencies

The digital euro is coming faster than most CFOs realise; Stablecoins are becoming a corporate treasury tool

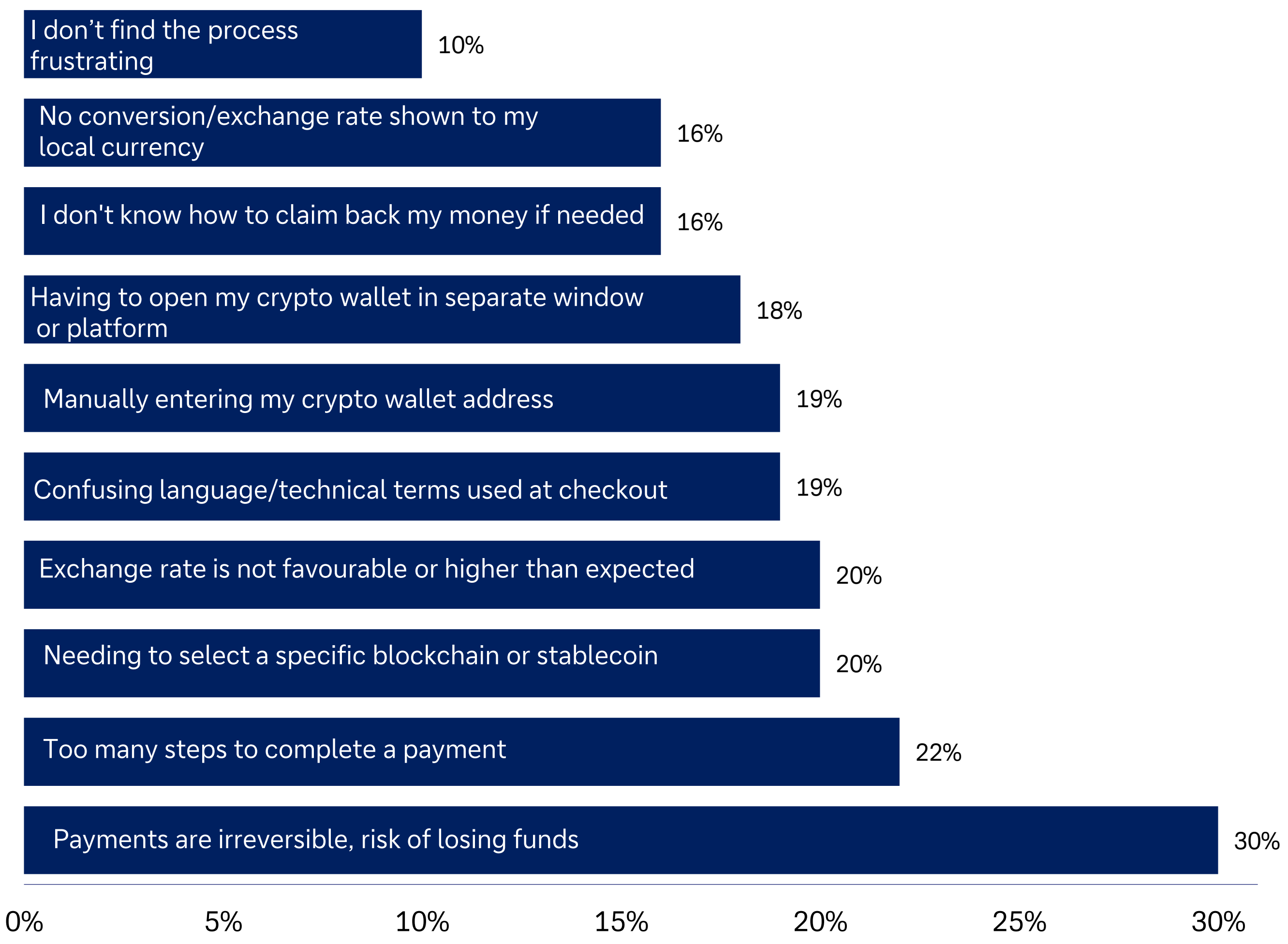
Stablecoins

- Over 80% of transitions occurred outside the US in 2025. Use cases expanding beyond crypto trading into treasury management, payments & settlements, banking & fintech, e-commerce & services.
- Top CFO risks: irreversible payments (30%), too many steps to complete a transaction (22%), fragmented wallet infrastructure.
- In Europe, political debate on permissibility of multi-jurisdictional stablecoins – agreement pending between ECB and European Commission.
- US CLARITY Act still pending. Key debate includes stablecoin yield and bank lending impact.
- March 2026: The OCC proposed stricter stablecoins rules, including a minimum capital floor of $5mn and a ban on interest payments to holders. This favours established payment giants and raises barriers for new entrants. See here.

CBDCS

- Wholesale: ECB's Project Pontes – a settlement solution for DLT-based large-value transaction – launches Q3 2026.
- Retail: European Parliament vote scheduled 23 June 2026. Pilot expected to begin in 2027; retail issuance targeted for 2029.

Challenges with stablecoin payments experience (BVNK Survey)



Source: Deutsche Bank Research, BVNK Survey (March 2026).

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Appendix 1

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